

Getting Noticed

A working course in sales, marketing and the psychology of trust — written for one person, in one situation. August 2026.

How to use this

Nine modules. Each is short on purpose: the idea, why it's true, what it means for *you* specifically, then a quiz. Do **one module a week** — Wednesday, in your small-win slot. Take the quiz without looking back. The answer key is at the end, with the reasoning, not just the letters.

This isn't theory for its own sake. Every module ends with something you can do that week with the assets you already have.

One honest word before we start

You said you have no backup plan, and that this is your life. So I'll be straight with you rather than encouraging: **a business at week three of real marketing does not pay rent, and shouldn't be asked to.** That's not failure, it's arithmetic. Your trading skill isn't the thing you fell off — it's the runway that buys this thing time to work. Protect the runway and you get to keep swinging. Bet the runway on a month-three miracle and one bad quarter ends the whole story, product and all.

Everything in this course assumes you're playing a 12–24 month game with your living covered some other way. That's the version where you win.

How to get the most out of me

You said it yourself: most of your talk is with Claude Code, so my memory isn't updated. Here's the actual situation, because it changes how you should work with me.

I don't remember our conversations. The repo does. Every session starts blank. What survives is what's written to files. That's why `START-HERE.md` , `DO-THIS-NEXT.md` , `KEYWORDS.md` and the rest exist — they're not paperwork, they're my memory. When you open a new conversation, the fastest thing you can type is:

"read START-HERE.md"

That single line gives a brand-new session everything: what the products are, where the launch stands, the rules of the house, what's deferred and why.

The five things that most change what you get back

Do this	Because
Say the format you want. "One paragraph." "Just the number." "A file I can print."	I default to explaining. You can switch that off and get answers instead of essays.
Say whether it's decided or open. "I've decided X, set it up" vs "should I do X?"	The first gets you execution. The second invites an opinion. You control which.
Say what it's for. "This goes to a rehab tomorrow."	Same request, completely different work, depending on who reads it.
Correct me the moment it drifts.	You did this with the duplicate scripts and the homework left in the emails. Both got fixed permanently. It's the highest-leverage thing you do.
Tell me to write it down. "Put that in the file."	Anything not written to a file dies when the conversation ends.

What I'm actually good at, and what I'm not

Good: writing in your voice, research at volume, building pages and tools, math, finding what's broken and proving it. **Not good:** I have no feedback loop — I can't see your analytics, can't feel a video die in the first three seconds, and I can't execute. I can't send an email, post a video, or get on a podcast. Everything I make still needs you to carry it out the door.

Quiz 0

1. You open a brand-new conversation about the business. What's the first thing you type, and why?
2. You want a short answer, not an explanation. What do you say?
3. True or false: telling me an idea in chat means a future session will know it.

Why anyone buys anything

Nobody buys a product. They buy a **changed situation**. The drill isn't the point; the hole is the point; and actually the shelf being up is the point.

For a purchase to happen, four things must be true at the same time. Miss any one and the sale doesn't happen — and importantly, *each one fails differently*, so knowing which one broke tells you what to fix.

Must be true	If it's missing you hear...	The fix
1. I have a problem	"I'm fine." "It's not that bad."	Language that names their exact situation back to them
2. It's worth solving now	"Maybe later." "I'll think about it."	Cost of staying the same, made concrete
3. This will actually work	"I've tried things before."	Proof — a story, a mechanism, someone like them
4. I trust the source	Silence. They just leave.	Module 2 — the whole next module

What this means for you

Your best-performing script — "Am I overreacting about my husband's drinking?" — works because it hits **#1** perfectly. She's been told she's overreacting. You say she isn't. She now knows she has a real problem with a real name.

Your weakest point is **#3**. You have no user stories yet — no "she used this and here's what changed." That's not a flaw in your marketing, it's just early. The first testimonial you ever get is worth more than fifty more videos, so **ask for it the moment someone tells you the app helped**.

Quiz 1

1. Someone reads your page, nods along, and leaves without signing up. Which of the four is most likely missing?
2. A woman comments "this is literally my life" but doesn't download. Which one is missing, and what would you say next?
3. Which of the four do you currently have the least evidence for, and what's the cheapest way to fix it?

Trust — how it's actually built

Trust isn't a vibe. It's four variables, and it behaves like a formula. This is the Trust Equation, from David Maister's work on professional advisors, and it's the most useful thing in this whole course:

Trust = (Credibility + Reliability + Closeness) ÷ Self-interest

Part	What it means	Where yours stands
Credibility	Do you know what you're talking about?	Very high. 38 years. Nobody can argue with lived experience.
Reliability	Do you do what you said, repeatedly?	Unproven. Built by showing up daily for months, not by claiming it.
Closeness	Can they be honest around you without shame?	Very high. You've been where they are. That's rare.
Self-interest	Does it feel like it's about you or them?	The whole game. It divides everything above it.

Look at where self-interest sits in that formula. It's the *denominator*. You can be credible, reliable and warm, and still be untrusted if you seem to be in it for yourself. And the reverse: reducing self-interest multiplies everything else you have. That's why "only send the link if they ask for it" isn't manners — it's the highest-leverage trust move you make.

The unity principle — your rarest asset

Robert Cialdini spent decades on the psychology of influence and eventually added a seventh principle to his famous six: **unity**. Not "this person is likeable" but "*this person is one of us.*" Shared identity beats persuasion because it skips the argument entirely.

You don't have to build unity. You *are* it. You're not a wellness brand talking at addicts. You're a man who was in it 38 years talking to people still in it. And there's a second unity you may be undercounting: a 50-year-old Black man in recovery, building software, with his wife beside him — that's a face almost entirely absent from recovery tech. For a lot of people, seeing you *is* the message.

Quiz 2

1. Which part of the trust equation is the one you can't fake or shortcut, and roughly how long does it take?
2. Why does putting your link in every reply *lower* trust, mathematically?
3. Name the two "unity" signals you carry that a competitor company can't copy.

Standing out when millions are doing the same thing

This was your real question, so here's the real answer.

You will never win on **volume** (people post 10× a day), **polish** (agencies), or **budget** (funded competitors outspend you 1000:1). Stop trying to compete on those three. They're rigged against you and always will be.

There are only two axes where a solo founder reliably beats a company:

1. Specificity

"Recovery app" competes with thousands. "The app for the wife of a man who drinks, built by a man who drank for 38 years" competes with **nobody**. The narrower the sentence, the less competition — and the more the right person feels you're talking directly to them, because you are.

The instinct is that narrowing shrinks your market. It doesn't. It shrinks your *competition* while making you the obvious choice for a specific person, who then tells other specific people.

2. Unfakeable proof

Anything a competitor can copy by tomorrow is not a differentiator. Your features can be copied. Your pages can be copied. Your prices can be undercut.

What cannot be copied: **38 years, free at 50, built it himself, wife in the story, and a section for the family that nobody else has built**. A funded startup with ten engineers cannot manufacture that in any amount of time for any amount of money.

Your one-sentence position:

"I was addicted for 38 years. I got free at 50. I built the app I needed — and unlike every other one, half of it is for the person who loves you."

That sentence should be recognisable in every video, every page, every email. Not repeated word-for-word — *recognisable*. When somebody can finish your sentence, you've broken through.

The uncomfortable part

Standing out is mostly a **time** problem, not a cleverness problem. Almost everyone who "tries what you're trying" quits inside 90 days, because nothing visible happens in the first 60. The compounding — search rankings, backlinks, an audience that recognises your face — starts after most people are gone.

You're roughly three weeks in. Feeling invisible right now isn't a signal that it's not working. It's what week three looks like for everybody.

Quiz 3

1. Name the three axes you cannot win on, and why trying costs you.
2. A competitor copies your 13 tracks, your pricing and your partner section next month. What do you still have?
3. Your video gets 200 views. Is that a signal to change the message, change the lane, or keep going? What would change your answer?

Getting attention — earned, owned, borrowed

There are only three kinds of attention, and it's worth knowing which one you're spending your day on.

Kind	What it is	Speed	Yours
Owned	Your videos, site, email list	Slow, compounds	SCRIPTS.md, Buffer, your pages
Borrowed	Someone else's audience lends you theirs	Fast, in bursts	OUTREACH.md, INFLUENCERS.md
Bought	Ads	Instant, stops when you stop	Not yet — see below

Borrowed attention is the most under-used and the fastest. One podcast with the right host puts you in front of more of exactly your people, in one hour, than a month of posting into an algorithm that doesn't know you yet. That's why `INFLUENCERS.md` exists and why it's worth more of your Tuesday than it's getting.

On ads: ads amplify a winner; they cannot create one. Until your stats page shows which specific message turns a stranger into a signup, ad money is just a faster way to be ignored. When one video proves itself, put \$5–10/day behind *that one*, on *that platform*. Not before.

The hook rule

The first line decides everything. On a short video you have about 2 seconds; in an email, the subject line and first sentence. Everything after that is only read by people the opening already caught.

Strong openings do one of three jobs: **name their exact situation** ("You've typed that question more than once"), **contradict what they expect** ("You're not overreacting"), or **open a loop** ("She found me on the floor of a bar"). Your scripts already do this — which is why the fix is repetition, not rewriting.

Quiz 4

1. Which of the three kinds of attention is fastest, and which is the only one that compounds while you sleep?
2. You have \$300. What's the honest best use of it right now, and what's the worst?
3. Write a first line for a video aimed at a man whose wife drinks. One sentence. Which of the three hook jobs does it do?

Gatekeepers and decision makers

Everyone treats the gatekeeper as an obstacle to beat. That framing is why most people fail. Recent sales research puts it plainly: **gatekeepers aren't obstacles, they're the fastest source of accurate information about who owns what** — and they answer honestly when you're honest first. 71% of reps say this is the hardest part of prospecting, and the ones who get through aren't smoother talkers. They're better prepared.

The three sentences that work

1. **Who you are, plainly.** No title inflation, no fake familiarity. "My name's Jacques, I built a recovery app."
2. **The problem you're about — in their world, not yours.** "Your article on recovery apps doesn't list anything for the family."
3. **A question only they can answer.** "Who edits that page?" Not "can I speak to the decision maker."

That third one is the trick. You're not asking for access — you're asking for *information*, which is what gatekeepers are actually there to give. And people help far more readily when the ask is small and specific.

Two things that stack the odds

Be recognised before you arrive. Decision-makers check you out before they respond. A comment on their post a week earlier means your name isn't cold when it lands. Same principle as unity — familiarity lowers the guard.

Use more than one door. Email plus one other channel books more than either alone. For you that means: the contact form, and the one personal email address you can find. Never the same day, and never pretending they're unrelated.

What this means for your Tuesdays

Your outreach emails already do all three sentences — that's not luck, it's how they were written. The 20 you haven't sent are worth more than any new tactic in this course.

One upgrade: when a form makes you pick a reason, never choose "admissions." Choose media, partnership, or general. Admissions routes you to a sales queue for patients, which is the one department that cannot help you.

Quiz 5

1. Why is "can I speak to whoever's in charge?" a weaker ask than "who edits that page?"
2. What's the single cheapest thing you can do a week *before* reaching out that measurably raises your odds?
3. A gatekeeper says "send it to info@ and we'll pass it along." Is that a brush-off, and what do you do?

The conversation that closes

Selling isn't talking someone into something. It's helping someone decide something they already half-want. The difference shows up in who's talking.

The person doing most of the talking is the person being sold to.

If you're talking 80% of the time, you're not selling — you're presenting, and presenting converts badly. The order that works:

1. **Ask about their situation.** Real questions, then silence. Silence is the tool most people can't stand and most need.
2. **Say it back to them, better than they said it.** "So it's not the drinking itself, it's never knowing which version of him walks in." When someone feels understood, they stop defending and start considering.
3. **Only then, connect it.** "That's the exact thing the partner section is for."
4. **Ask a small next step.** Not "buy this." "Want me to send you the link?"

Objections aren't rejection

"I need to think about it" almost never means what it says. It usually means one of the four from Module 1 is unmet — most often #3, "will this actually work." The move is not to push. It's to ask: **"What would you need to know to feel sure?"** Then answer exactly that, and nothing else.

The rule that outranks every sales technique

Never sell to someone in pain. If a person's opening line tells you they're in crisis, the conversation is not a sales conversation. Point at 988 and be a human being. This costs you conversions and is non-negotiable — and, as it happens, it's also the single most trust-building thing anyone will ever see you do.

Quiz 6

1. What percentage of the conversation should you be talking, and why does more hurt you?
2. Someone says "I'll think about it." What's your next sentence?
3. A woman replies to a post at 2am saying she can't do this anymore. What do you do, and what do you not do?

Follow-up, and the numbers that matter

Follow-up

Most business is lost to silence, not to "no." One follow-up roughly doubles your response rate. Two is fine. Beyond that you're not persistent, you're a problem — and your name gets attached to that feeling permanently.

The rule already in your outreach file is the right one: **one follow-up, 7–10 days later, then let it go.** A short one that adds something, never "just bumping this."

The only four numbers you need

Number	What it tells you	What to do
Leads by source	Which door people come through	Make more for the door that's opening
Signups	Whether the message converts, not just entertains	Views without signups = wrong audience or weak #3
Trials	Whether the free tier makes people want more	Signups without trials = a product question, not marketing
Replies	Whether outreach lands	Zero from 20 = the email, not the list

Everything else — views, likes, followers — is weather. Interesting, not actionable. A video with 200 views and 2 signups beats one with 50,000 and none, every single time.

Your honest scoreboard right now

Zero stranger signups, roughly ten outreach emails sent, three weeks of real posting. That is **exactly** where a business should be at this point, and it tells you nothing yet — you don't have enough data to conclude anything, good or bad. The first real decision point is **50 outreach emails and 60 days of consistent posting.** Before that, changes are guessing.

Quiz 7

1. You send 20 emails and get zero replies. What do you change — the list, the email, or nothing yet? Why?
2. A video gets 40,000 views and no signups. What does that tell you?
3. Why is "followers" a worse number to chase than "leads by source"?

Final exam

No looking back. Write your answers out — writing forces the thinking that recognising an answer skips.

1. State your one-sentence position from memory.
2. Trust has four parts. Name them, and say which one divides the others.
3. You're introduced to someone who runs a network of treatment centres. You have two minutes. What do you say — and what do you ask?
4. Name three things a funded competitor could copy from you by next month, and two they could never copy.
5. Where should the next \$300 go, and where should it absolutely not go?
6. You've posted daily for 60 days. Stats: 3 signups, all from one lane. What do you do next week?
7. Someone in crisis replies to a post. Write your actual first sentence.
8. What's the one line you type to bring a brand-new session up to speed?

Answer key

Quiz 0. (1) "read START-HERE.md" — it's the shared memory; chat doesn't persist between sessions. (2) Say the format up front: "one paragraph," "just the number." (3) **False**. If it isn't written to a file it's gone when the conversation ends.

Quiz 1. (1) Usually **#2** (worth solving now) or **#4** (trust) — they agreed but felt no urgency, or didn't trust the source enough to hand over an email. (2) **#3** — she believes the problem, not the solution. Next words should be proof, not a pitch. (3) **#3**, and the cheapest fix is asking your first happy user for one sentence you can quote.

Quiz 2. (1) **Reliability** — it's built only by repetition over time, months not weeks. (2) Because self-interest is the denominator: every unasked-for link raises it, which divides down all the credibility and closeness you've earned. (3) Lived experience (38 years, free at 50) and being a 50-year-old Black man in recovery building his own software with his wife in the story. Neither can be hired, bought, or manufactured.

Quiz 3. (1) Volume, polish, budget — trying costs you because you lose slowly while burning the time and money that specificity would have converted. (2) Your story, your face, your wife, and the trust of anyone who's already watched you. Features are copyable; a life isn't. (3) **Keep going** — 200 views is noise at week three. What would change the answer: 60 days of consistency with signups still at zero across every lane.

Quiz 4. (1) Borrowed is fastest; owned compounds. (2) Best: nothing — or a modest amount of AI video for the origin story you already have shot. Worst: ads, before anything has proven it converts. (3) Any answer that names his exact situation in his words — e.g. "Nobody asks the husband how he's holding up." That's job one, naming the situation.

Quiz 5. (1) Because it asks for *access*, which gatekeepers are paid to protect, instead of *information*, which they're paid to give — and it signals you didn't do your homework. (2) Engage with them publicly a week earlier — a comment, a share — so your name isn't cold on arrival. (3) Not necessarily a brush-off. Send it to info@ and reference the gatekeeper's name in the first line: "Your colleague suggested I send this through."

Quiz 6. (1) Roughly 30% — more and you're presenting, which converts badly, and you stop learning which of the four is missing. (2) "What would you need to know to feel sure?" (3) You respond as a person, point at 988, and do not mention the app at all. Not a tactic — a line.

Quiz 7. (1) **Nothing yet** — 20 is too small a sample. At 50 with zero replies, change the email before the list. (2) Wrong audience, or a hook that entertains without connecting to the problem. High views, no signups is the classic symptom of a video that people enjoyed but didn't recognise themselves in. (3) Because followers don't tell you what to do next week, and leads by source does.

Final exam

1. Any wording carrying: 38 years, free at 50, built it myself, and the half nobody else built — for the person who loves them. **2.** Credibility, reliability, closeness, self-interest; self-interest divides. **3.** Say the gap (nothing exists for the family), say your credential (38 years, free at 50, built it), then ask: "Who decides what tools your counsellors recommend?" End asking, not pitching. **4.** Copyable: features, tracks, pricing, page copy, design.

Not copyable: your story, your wife's side of it, and the trust you've already built with anyone watching. **5.** To borrowed attention (outreach, podcasts) and staying alive long enough to compound. Not to ads. **6.** Do *more* of that one lane — that's your first real signal in 60 days. Don't diversify away from the only thing that worked. **7.** Something human with no pitch: "I'm glad you said something. Are you safe right now?" Then 988. **8.** "read START-HERE.md"

Getting Noticed — August 2026. One module a week, in the Wednesday slot. The course is not the work; the Tuesday emails and the daily posting are the work. This just makes sure they're aimed at the right thing.